Pinocchio

By AJ Jacobs

Once upon a time in a faraway city lived a kindly old wood-carver named Geppetto. All day long, he sat in his tiny workshop and carved puppets out of wood with his crude jackknife.

"Boy, this whittling sure gets to be a drag," said Geppetto one day. "Looka me. Talking to a pine-top dummy. If only you was a real kid! I could get you a paper route and take it easy for a while."

No sooner had kindly old Geppetto shuffled off to bed than a good fairy mysteriously appeared. The fairy figured that kindly old Geppetto deserved better, and decided to grant him his wish. She tapped the puppet on the head and POOF it sprang to life.

"Ugh," groaned the puppet. "Do I need a cup of joe. Hey, who are you'?"

"I'm the good fairy who just brought you to life," said the fairy.

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"Yeah, but looka me! I'm still wood! I want to be a real boy!"

INTRODUCTION

Walt Disney's immortal masterpiece Pinocchio has inspired millions to wish upon a star and always "let your conscience be your guide." On a magical starlit night, a blue fairy brings Geppetto's beloved marionette Pinocchio to life, beginning a fantastic adventure that will test the puppet's bravery, loyalty and honesty - virtues he must learn to become a real boy. Despite the warnings of his wise friend, Jimmy Cricket, Pinocchio gets entangled in one humorous predicament after another. In AJ Jacobs parody of this classic, Jimmy Cricket is missing and the only virtue that eludes our hero is that of bravery, and an overwhelming push by Geppetto to make it BIG on TV. Pinocchio by AJ Jacobs.

The fairy told the puppet that yes, one day, he could be a real boy. But as always, there was a catch. The puppet had to perform a brave deed. With that, the fairy mysteriously disappeared and the puppet ran to wake Geppetto and tell him the good news;

"Hey, kindly old Geppetto," said the puppet,shaking the wood-carver awake.

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"Whatever you sellin' I don't want," grunted Geppetto. .

"No, it's me, the puppet you carved. The good fairy brought me to life."

Geppetto bolted up, clicked his heels, and shouted, "Yabba-dabba-doo!" (Italian for Hooray!) "Oh, I so happy! A talking puppet with no strings? " You're worth a fortune! I'm gonna call you Pinocchio and start my own television show."

"But I don't want to be on television," said the puppet. "I want to do a brave deed and become a real boy."

"You outta your mind, Splinters? Stay wood. Stay wood! You gonna be bigger than Hunch and Juicy."

"That's Punch and Judy," said the puppet. But Geppetto wasn't listening. He was already on the phone with J. Quincy Flogg, the president of the television network, telling him about this hot new act. Flogg loved the concept and, after three dozen focus groups, 22 studies, and 158 meetings, he boldly agreed to give Geppetto a show. It was tentatively titled Pinocchio

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Doody Show and after some hard bargaining, Geppetto got himself a million dollars and two coffee breaks for each show.

Everybody soon got to work. Pinocchio was sent to a personal trainer to make sure his pine was hard but flexible. He got some high-priced wooden surgery for his nose, which mysteriously grew each time he lied. (Which, in show business, was quite a bit.) And he started shooting a commercial for lemon-scented wood polish-no easy task.

"Take it from the top!" yelled Geppetto, on the commercial's set.

"But kindly old Geppetto," sighed Pinocchio, "I've already done the commercial fifty times."

"Hey, knothead, you know what this is'?" asked Geppetto, holding up a piece of paper.

"It's paper,"

"Atsa right," said Geppetto. "And you know what it's made of?"

"Wood."

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"Atsa right again. Now. . . you wanna wind up as a big brown roll in a butcher shop?"

"No, sir," said Pinocchio.

"Okay. Then let's see that soft smile and the hard sell,"

Finally, all was in readiness for the big show. Backstage, Pinocchio sat in his chair, his makeup artist applying a little varnish. The director approached him. "Don't worry, Pinocchio," he said. "If you forget your lines, you can always look at the cue cards."

Pinocchio shrugged his shoulders. He didn't need any cue cards, he said. He knew his part. Now who should overhear this but J. Quincy Flogg, the president of the network. He was stunned. "A TV star not using idiot cards! Why, that's the bravest thing I've ever heard."

It was quite brave. In fact, it was such a brave deed that the mere thought of it instantly turned Pinocchio from a wood puppet into a real boy. But as soon as that happened, the network canceled the show. Geppetto tried to sell his idea to Disney as a nice family

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movie, but Disney couldn't care less. Geppetto and Pinocchio found themselves penniless and on the street.

Just then, the good fairy appeared again.

"Oh, I love happy endings," she said. "Finally Pinocchio's a real boy and he can be your son and live with you forever."

"You offa your head?" shouted Geppetto. "I want to be lonely. I don't like kids. I'm leaving." Geppetto sulked off to his workshop, where he made hundreds and hundreds of other puppets, hoping that one would come to life again someday, which never happened.

The good fairy comforted the little boy. "Let him go. You see, he isn't your real father at all. That's your real father." She pointed at J. Quincy Flogg, the head of the network.

Pinocchio was overjoyed to find his real father at last, and Flogg was happy too. He was so happy he gave his son a starring role in the nighttime soap opera Faraway Hamlet 90210, even though he had minimal acting skills.

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AWARD HISTORY

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